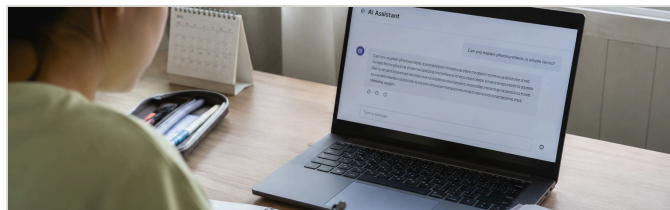




AI in Education

Is easier learning better learning?

A tireless tutor for everyone sounds like progress. The harder question is what students stop doing.



A student studies with the help of an AI assistant on a laptop.



Listen to the article

Scan the QR code or visit the link.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. Think of something you learned the hard way. Would you have learned it as well if it had been easy?
2. Is asking AI to improve your essay different from asking a friend to check it? Where is the line?

A student stuck on a calculus problem at midnight once had few options: wait for class, text a friend, or stay stuck. Today she can ask a machine that never tires, never judges, and will explain the idea a dozen different ways until it clicks. For many learners, this is simply what studying now looks like. Whether it is also what learning looks like is another matter.

The case for AI in education is compelling. A patient, personalized tutor was once a privilege of wealthy families; now it is available to anyone with a phone. Why, then, should any student stay stuck? Because learning has an awkward feature. Much of it happens precisely when we **grapple with** something difficult. The effort that feels like failure is often the learning itself, and a tool designed to remove friction may remove the part that mattered.

Early research hints at the tension. In some studies, students who practiced with an AI assistant solved more problems, then did worse than their peers once the tool was taken away. The machine had become a **crutch** rather than a coach. Teachers describe a quieter shift, too: essays grow more polished while class discussion grows thinner, as if fluency were rising **at the expense of** thought.

None of this settles the argument. Calculators were once expected to **erode** basic arithmetic, and the internet to end memory; neither turned out quite as feared. Some schools ban AI outright; others teach students to argue with it. Skeptics reply that students determined to **cut corners** will always find a way, whatever the policy says.

If a machine can do the thinking, what exactly is school for?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the expressions (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|---------------------------|--|
| 1. cut corners ____ | A. to wear away gradually |
| 2. a crutch ____ | B. while causing loss or harm to |
| 3. erode ____ | C. to take shortcuts that lower quality |
| 4. grapple with ____ | D. to struggle to deal with something hard |
| 5. at the expense of ____ | E. something depended on too heavily |

TRUE OR FALSE

Judge what the article states *or implies*. Circle T or F.

- | | | |
|---|----------|----------|
| 1. AI tutors mainly help wealthy families. | T | F |
| 2. The writer sees struggle as partly useful. | T | F |
| 3. Some students did worse without AI. | T | F |
| 4. The calculator case settles the debate. | T | F |
| 5. Polish can mask weak thinking. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 When has a shortcut cost you more than it saved? What did you lose?
- 2 Is AI more like a calculator, a tutor, or a ghostwriter? Does it depend on the subject?
- 3 Why might a tool that helps weaker students today leave them weaker later?
- 4 Should schools ban AI, teach it, or redesign assessment around it? What does each assume?
- 5 If machines can produce polished work, what should a qualification actually prove?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

ONE STUDY, SIX HEADLINES

A study finds students using an AI tutor scored higher, but remembered less a month later.

Every headline below reports that same study. Note what each one leaves out, then tick the one you would print.

HEADLINE	IT STRESSES	IT LEAVES OUT	PRINT
"AI Tutors Boost Test Scores"	the short-term gain	_____	☐
"Machines Are Making Students Forget"	the later loss, and who to blame	_____	☐
"Students Learn Faster With AI, Scientists Say"	speed, backed by authority	_____	☐
"Is Your Child's AI Helper Harming Them?"	a parent's fear	_____	☐
"Study Raises Questions About AI in Class"	uncertainty	_____	☐
"Mixed Results: AI Is No Shortcut"	balance, plus a verdict	_____	☐

YOUR CHOICE Headline you would print: No. ____ The one word you would change in it: _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Which headline is accurate yet still misleading? How can both be true?
 - 2 Compare with another pair. Defend your headline against theirs.
 - 3 What would you need to know about the study before trusting any of these headlines?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with an expression from the box.
Change the form if you need to.

erode at the expense of cut corners
grapple with a crutch

- 1 He _____ by pasting in answers.
- 2 Spellcheck has become _____ for me.
- 3 Constant alerts slowly _____ our focus.
- 4 Good students _____ hard problems.
- 5 Speed often comes _____ depth.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

"AI is making students faster, not smarter." To what extent do you agree?

Write 200–250 words. Address the strongest opposing view before you answer it.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • PROPOSE • DEFEND

In small groups, build one position and hold it under pressure.

ROLE You advise a university where many essays are now partly written by AI.

PROPOSE Recommend ONE assessment policy. Say what it protects, and what it sacrifices.

DEFEND Present in two minutes. A student group then argues it is unfair. Answer them without abandoning your policy.